Language Arts Syllabus

Grades 1–4

2026–2027

INSTRUCTOR INFORMATION

Instructor	Email	Class Days
Tiffany Young	Tiffany@rivertech.me	Monday–Friday
Mary Hegelund	Mary@rivertech.me	Monday–Friday

COURSE OVERVIEW

Language Arts develops students' skills in phonics, reading, vocabulary, comprehension, handwriting, grammar, writing, literature, speaking, and listening through structured instruction, individual practice, and meaningful engagement with books and ideas.

Students use Kumon Reading and Writing Workbooks at their appropriate grade and skill level. Kumon follows a gradual, step-by-step approach that builds foundational skills before progressing to more complex reading comprehension, grammar, and written expression.

Students use Khan Academy Kids for phonics and foundational reading practice and learn approximately 5–10 new sight words each week. Reading instruction is individualized. Students regularly read BOB Books and other level-appropriate books aloud one-on-one to the teacher, progressing to increasingly challenging texts according to their individual reading ability.

Handwriting workbooks are used to develop correct letter formation, legibility, spacing, and increasingly fluent handwriting.

Literature is an important part of the course. The teacher regularly reads classic children's literature aloud, exposing students to rich vocabulary, quality storytelling, characters, themes, and ideas beyond what students may yet be able to read independently. Literature is discussed together through questions, narration, comprehension, and conversation.

Students develop written expression through guided writing prompts, story writing, and opportunities for free and creative writing when developmentally appropriate. Younger students begin with words,

sentences, and simple stories and gradually progress toward organized paragraphs and longer compositions.

Verbal discussion is part of daily learning. Students practice listening attentively, asking and answering questions, retelling information and stories, expressing their thoughts, explaining their reasoning, and participating respectfully in conversations with teachers and classmates.

The overall goal is to develop confident readers, thoughtful communicators, and capable writers while allowing students to progress according to their individual level and readiness.

COURSE MATERIALS

Required Materials

- Kumon Reading and Writing Workbooks (at the student's appropriate grade and skill level)
- A dedicated handwriting workbook
- Access to Khan Academy Kids for phonics and foundational reading practice
- BOB Books or other level-appropriate readers for one-on-one reading practice

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Reading & Phonics

Students develop phonemic awareness, phonics, decoding, word recognition, vocabulary, fluency, and comprehension through Khan Academy Kids, Kumon Reading, sight-word practice, and individual reading.

Students learn approximately 5–10 new sight words each week and regularly read aloud one-on-one with the teacher. Beginning readers may use BOB Books and other early readers, while more advanced students progress to books appropriate to their individual reading level.

The teacher monitors decoding, accuracy, fluency, expression, vocabulary, and comprehension.

Reading Comprehension

Grade Band	Focus
Grades 1–2	Vocabulary, vowel and consonant patterns, following directions, sequencing, identifying important information, answering who/what/where/when/why questions, and understanding short passages and stories.
Grades 3–4	Vocabulary in context, prefixes and suffixes, sequencing, comparing and contrasting, making predictions, cause and effect, main ideas and supporting details, character understanding, and increasingly complex reading comprehension.

Literature

Students listen regularly to classic and high-quality children's literature read aloud by the teacher.

Read-aloud literature develops listening comprehension, vocabulary, imagination, understanding of story structure and characters, and appreciation for quality literature. Students engage with texts through oral discussion, questions, retelling, prediction, interpretation, and connections to their own knowledge and experiences.

Students encounter both literary and informational texts throughout Language Arts and other subject areas.

Writing & Grammar

Grade Band	Focus
Grade 1	Sight words, punctuation, nouns, pronouns, verbs, adjectives, simple sentences, letter writing, and beginning stories.
Grade 2	Vocabulary, nouns, pronouns, verbs, adjectives, adverbs, contractions, subjects and predicates, punctuation, and story writing.
Grade 3	Punctuation, subject-verb agreement, sentence types, descriptive writing, and organized one- and two-paragraph compositions.
Grade 4	Complete sentences, combining and expanding sentences, complex sentences, main ideas and supporting details, topic development, and organized multi-paragraph compositions.

Students also practice narrative, descriptive, informative, and age-appropriate opinion writing through teacher-selected writing activities.

Story & Creative Writing

Students are given opportunities to develop their own ideas through story prompts and free writing according to their age, skill level, and readiness.

Instruction progresses naturally from drawing and labeling, to sentences and simple stories, and eventually to organized paragraphs and longer pieces. Emphasis is placed on helping students communicate their ideas clearly and develop confidence and enjoyment in writing, alongside appropriate grammar, spelling, punctuation, and organization.

Handwriting

Students use dedicated handwriting workbooks to develop legible and increasingly fluent handwriting. Instruction and practice include correct letter formation, size, spacing, alignment, and neatness, progressing according to students' developmental level.

Speaking & Listening

Verbal communication and discussion are incorporated into daily learning. Students practice listening attentively and following oral directions; asking and answering relevant questions; retelling and summarizing stories and information; expressing opinions and explaining their thinking; discussing literature and classroom topics; taking turns and responding appropriately to others; and speaking clearly when sharing ideas.

Individualized Learning

Students' reading and writing abilities do not always correspond exactly to their grade placement. Instruction is differentiated according to individual skill level and readiness.

Students may work at, above, or below their enrolled grade level in particular Language Arts materials. Teachers adjust reading materials, writing expectations, phonics instruction, and one-on-one support to provide an appropriate level of challenge while building toward grade-level proficiency.

COURSE GOALS

Reading fluency and strong reading comprehension are key goals of the elementary Language Arts program. Our goal is for students to become fluent, independent readers with solid comprehension by the end of Grade 4. Many students achieve this earlier, while others may need additional time and support. Instruction is adjusted to each student's individual development while continually working toward these goals.

By the end of the course, students will demonstrate continued growth in phonics, word recognition, reading fluency, vocabulary, comprehension, handwriting, grammar, written expression, literature appreciation, speaking, and listening.

Students will increasingly be able to read independently, understand and discuss what they read, communicate their ideas verbally, and express their thoughts clearly in writing.